DEEPTI CHAVAN

40, Patient Advocate, Mumbai

A TERRIFYING DISEASE

Deepti underwent treatment for Multi-Drug-Resistant tuberculosis (MDR-TB) for six long years. The drugs she was prescribed had extreme side-effects: "One drug, cycloserine, makes you suicidal, irritable....you just lose your mind. The family feels that the patient is doing this because he/she is frustrated, but it's the medicine which makes them behave thus." Another drug, clofazimine, turned her skin dark, and the drastic change in her appearance scared her further. "The side effects of MDR treatment can be gruelling, and only a few patients are properly informed about this. Now, I am trying to provide to others the counselling that I missed out on," she says.



Photograph by MANDAR DEODHAR